

Risks Facing Chinese Mining Companies in the Sahel

Introduction

China's engagement in the Sahel demonstrates its high tolerance for political and security risks, driven first and foremost by what the region can supply. Beijing views the Sahel as strategically important because of its large reserves of critical minerals and energy resources. These include lithium, uranium, petroleum, gold, and other strategic minerals used for electric vehicles, renewable energy technologies, advanced manufacturing, and long-term energy security. Rather than relying solely on the international markets, Beijing has sought to secure direct access to these resources through long-term mining investments and the construction of infrastructure under the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI).

However, the environment China has chosen to invest in is increasingly unstable. Military coups and violent extremist insurgencies have weakened African state institutions and fostered the growth of jihadist and criminal networks, driving up the political, security, and operational risks for Chinese mining investments. As reported by War on the Rocks, the expulsion of Western forces has created a security vacuum that has worsened these risks, raising the threat to infrastructure, transport corridors, and Chinese personnel.

Strategic Context

For decades, minerals were extracted and exported from the continent with little economic benefit for the countries they came from. Under the banner of resource nationalism, African governments are now seeking greater control over their resources and are keen to keep more stages of mineral processing and manufacturing at home.

To realise those ambitions, they have introduced, or are considering, export restrictions on unprocessed and critical minerals, local processing requirements such as Mali's Local Content Law, which requires international firms to source parts, logistics, and labour from Malian-owned businesses, and the renegotiation of mining contracts, as seen in Burkina Faso, where the state has moved to block multinational companies from retaining sole ownership of national mineral revenues.

The wave of coups since 2020 has seen chiefly the expulsion and evacuation of French and United States forces, and United Nations peacekeeping missions, driving the Sahel's pivot toward China. This has prompted China to strategically position itself as a powerful alternative to traditional Western powers, offering engagement through institutions like the Global Security Initiative (GSI) and the Forum on China-Africa Cooperation (FOCAC).

Chinese companies have capitalized on the shifting political and economic landscape by expanding investment in gold, lithium, and uranium projects, often with the support of military-led governments. For many of these governments, particularly those led by military juntas, Chinese investors provide an important source of revenue at a time of political uncertainty, security threats, and international isolation. Backed by state-owned banks, Chinese companies are willing to invest in politically unstable regions, where Western countries are hesitant to operate. Furthermore, China's policy of non-interference lets it deal directly with central governments and ruling elites to access critical minerals. The arrangement is a mutually beneficial one, helping China to secure natural resources and the Sahel to secure foreign funding and military aid.

Political Risks

Political instability is the principal source of uncertainty for Chinese mining investments in the Sahel. Recent coups in the region have weakened state institutions, deteriorated the regional security environment, and encouraged resource nationalism, creating greater uncertainty for foreign mining and resource investments across the region.

China's long-standing policy of political non-interference has given it a competitive advantage over Western countries in the extraction of natural resources. Yet the repeated coups have disrupted that engagement, altering the regulatory framework and raising the risk of dissolution of existing contracts, demand for higher royalties, and resource nationalism that takes hold. The risk for Chinese mining companies is the increase in state-ownership, local processing requirements, including requiring the host country's government to hold a certain percentage of shares in the mining projects free of charge, and contract renegotiations. As such, Chinese mining companies are struggling to cope with the pace of due diligence and management changes, as these significant policy adjustments threaten their normal operations. Even without military coups, Chinese mining companies face comparable political risk. Changes in leadership in major mineral-producing

countries are often accompanied by significant shifts in mining and resource policy, which harm their interests and weaken investment confidence.

Security Risks

The evacuation of Western forces marks a symbolic end to Europe's post-colonial security dominance in the Sahel. With the closing down of drone bases and the reduction of aid programs, fragile states are left scrambling for alternatives to combat militants who control vast rural territories.

China's security engagement with Africa is not new. Beijing has engaged in security matters on the continent through institutions like GSI and FOCAC, and has helped combat insurgencies and armed groups, providing millions of dollars in military equipment, intelligence sharing, and humanitarian aid. In 2025, Burkina Faso received shipments of Chinese-manufactured military equipment as part of a broader effort to strengthen the government's armed forces amid a persistent insurgent threat. That engagement has largely followed China's growing economic interest in the region. Its approach to security is driven by the need to defend its economic stability, commercial initiatives, and the rising number of Chinese workers present in the region.

The result of the region's instability is that the central Sahel is now one of the most active conflict zones, leaving mining sites, access roads, and supply convoys directly exposed. China's existing economically driven, non-interference approach is arguably not enough to secure its interests, as militants are now specifically targeting Chinese-run and Chinese-operated mines and the energy, extraction, and transport infrastructure around them. Chinese nationals have been abducted in mine-related attacks and killed in militia attacks elsewhere, and firms deploying large numbers of expatriate staff present a high-value target. According to 2025 data compiled by the conflict monitor ACLED, Chinese workers suffered the majority of foreign abductions in Africa: of 89 foreigners kidnapped that year, 38 held Chinese passports. BBC Monitoring found that around 70% of kidnapping cases across the continent occurred in Mali and neighboring Niger, where many Chinese nationals work in the gold-rich mines.

Operational Risks

Supply chain disruption is the biggest day-to-day risk for Chinese mines. According to Africa Defense Forum (ADF), jihadist groups systematically target Chinese mining operations, setting up chokepoints to fund insurgency rather than seizing goods. The high kidnapping rate of Chinese personnel compounds the problem, halting operations and forcing Chinese embassies to issue urgent evacuation orders for high-risk zones.

The geography makes things worse. Landlocked regions depend on long transport corridors through insecure territory, which leads to delayed mineral exports and raises transportation costs, against a backdrop of weak transport and communication infrastructure. Insurgents target heavy machinery and attack corridors used to extract resources. Diesel-intensive mines are also facing fuel blockade, with jihadist groups attacking tankers and bombing nearby pipelines, as seen with the Niger-Benin pipeline. The result has been acute shortages and cuts to diesel-generated power, while army-imposed movement restrictions and convoy attacks add further fragility. Border closures following political crises deepen Chinese mines' dependence on the political stability of transit countries. To survive in conflict zones, operational costs are soaring, as companies must hire private security teams to protect their daily perimeters.

Strategic Assessment

China's engagement with Africa rests on the policy of non-interference, which stems from its "Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence" introduced in 1953. The principles hold strictly against interference in national politics and insist on respect for territorial sovereignty and integrity.

In the Sahel, however, non-interference is failing to protect Chinese mining companies and investments. Beijing prioritizes support for and communication with central governments and military juntas over engagement with local leaders who might address grassroots governance failures, poverty, and local grievances that drive the region's insurgencies. This leaves China stuck backing weak regimes without the ability to improve security or reforms, exposing Chinese mining companies to perpetual uncertainty.

As Chinese investments become increasingly concentrated in politically unstable regions, Beijing faces mounting expectations to protect its citizens, commercial assets, and strategic supply chains. This presents China with a broader geopolitical dilemma. Protecting its citizens and investments may require Beijing to take a more active role in regional security through peacekeeping, security

cooperation, intelligence sharing, or other forms of engagement. Yet a greater involvement risks undermining the very policy of non-interference that has been central to China's engagement with Africa.

To protect its investment and citizens, China will have to reanalyze this policy, deciding whether to hold on to the position that has made it a favorable partner for military-led governments or succumb to the regional pressures to abandon it.

The core dynamic remains a high-reward, high-risk trade. The assets are strategic, but the environment of unstable juntas, aggressive resource nationalism, and a spreading insurgency is deteriorating, putting considerable risk to personnel, assets, and operations.

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